

Psalms 103

Bless the Lord, O My Soul

Bless the Lord, O my soul: and forget not all his benefits
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 Bless the LORD, O my soul: and all that is within me, bless his holy name.
- 2 Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits:
- 3 Who forgiveth all thine iniquities; who healeth all thy diseases;
- 4 Who redeemeth thy life from destruction; who crowneth thee with lovingkindness and tender mercies;
- 5 Who satisfieth thy mouth with good things; so that thy youth is renewed like the eagle's.
- 6 The LORD executeth righteousness and judgment for all that are oppressed.
- 7 He made known his ways unto Moses, his acts unto the children of Israel.
- 8 The LORD is merciful and gracious, slow to anger, and plenteous in mercy.
- 9 He will not always chide: neither will he keep his anger for ever.
- 10 He hath not dealt with us after our sins; nor rewarded us according to our iniquities.
- 11 For as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is his mercy toward them that fear him.
- 12 As far as the east is from the west, so far hath he removed our transgressions from us.
- 13 Like as a father pitieth his children, so the LORD pitieth them that fear him.
- 14 For he knoweth our frame; he remembereth that we are dust.
- 15 As for man, his days are as grass: as a flower of the field, so he flourisheth.
- 16 For the wind passeth over it, and it is gone; and the place thereof shall know it no more.
- 17 But the mercy of the LORD is from everlasting to everlasting upon them that fear him, and his righteousness unto children's children;
- 18 To such as keep his covenant, and to those that remember his commandments to do them.
- 19 The LORD hath prepared his throne in the heavens; and his kingdom ruleth over all.
- 20 Bless the LORD, ye his angels, that excel in strength, that do his commandments, hearkening unto the voice of his word.
- 21 Bless ye the LORD, all ye his hosts; ye ministers of his, that do his pleasure.
- 22 Bless the LORD, all his works in all places of his dominion: bless the LORD, O my soul.

2 · CONTEXT

One of the most beloved psalms of personal praise, Psalm 103 is structured as a deliberate act of self-address—the psalmist commanding his own soul to remember and bless God—before moving outward to describe God's character in some of Scripture's richest compressed language: merciful, gracious, slow to anger, plenteous in mercy, forgiving as far as east is from west. Henry notes that the psalm's opening command to 'forget not' assumes forgetting is the natural danger; deliberate remembrance is the corrective discipline the whole psalm models.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-5

The psalmist addresses his own soul directly, commanding it, along with everything within him, to bless God's holy name and not forget His benefits. Those benefits are then listed concretely: forgiveness of iniquities, healing of diseases, redemption from destruction, a crown of lovingkindness and tender mercy, satisfaction with good things, and renewed youth like the eagle's—specific gifts named, not vague gratitude.

Verse 6-10

God's character is displayed through action: He executes righteousness and judgment for all who are oppressed, made His ways known to Moses and His acts to the children of Israel. The often-repeated formula follows: merciful and gracious, slow to anger, plenteous in mercy, not one who chides forever or keeps anger always, and—crucially—not dealing with His people according to what their sins actually deserve.

Verse 11-14

Three vivid comparisons deepen the point: as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is His mercy toward those who fear Him; as far as east is from west, so far has He removed their transgressions; as a father pities his children, so the Lord pities those who fear Him, because He knows their frame and remembers they are but dust. Human frailty is met with fatherly compassion, not impatience.

Verse 15-18

Human life is acknowledged honestly as brief—like grass, like a flower of the field, gone when the wind passes over it and its place remembered no more. Against that fragility, God's mercy toward those who fear Him is everlasting, and His righteousness extends to children's children who keep His covenant and remember to do His commandments—permanence answering transience.

Verse 19-22

The psalm widens into cosmic praise: the Lord has prepared His throne in the heavens, and His kingdom rules over all. Angels who excel in strength and do His commandments are called to bless Him, along with all His hosts and ministers who do His pleasure, and all His works in every place of His dominion. The psalm closes exactly as it began—bless the Lord, O my soul—personal praise framed by, and now joined to, the praise of the entire created order.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Gratitude toward God is not a passive feeling to be waited for but a deliberate discipline the soul must be commanded into, actively remembering specific benefits that are otherwise easily forgotten. God's mercy is defined here with unusual precision—slow to anger, not dealing with people as their sins deserve, removing transgressions as far as east is from west—and is matched to human frailty with the tenderness of a father who remembers his children are only dust.

Application for life today.

Follow the psalm's structure literally: address your own soul directly, naming specific benefits from God you are at risk of forgetting, rather than settling for a general sense of thankfulness. When you are aware of your own frailty or mortality (vv. 15–16), let that awareness lead you toward God's fatherly compassion (vv. 13–14) rather than despair, remembering He already knows and accounts for your frame. Let the psalm's final widening—from your own soul to angels and all creation—remind you that your personal praise joins something far larger than your private circumstances.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What specific benefit from God have you recently 'forgotten,' and how would deliberately naming it, as this psalm commands the soul to do (vv. 1–5), change your gratitude today?

2. How does the image of a father who 'knows our frame' and 'remembers that we are dust' (vv. 13–14) reshape how you view your own limitations or failures?

3. What would it mean to genuinely believe that God has removed your transgressions 'as far as the east is from the west' (v. 12), rather than keeping a private tally?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).